

Viollet-le-Duc

Through his restorations and descriptions of medieval buildings, Eugène Emmanuel Viollet-le-Duc (1814–79) inspired the Gothic Revival in France. Eschewing the neoclassicism of the École des Beaux-Arts, he studied French and Italian medieval architecture, and his first restoration for the Ministry of Historical Monuments was Saint-Germain-l'Auxerrois (1838) in Paris. The following year he oversaw the restoration of the abbey church of the Madeleine at Vézelay. With Jean-Baptiste-Antoine Lassus (1807–57), he worked on Sainte-Chapelle and Notre-Dame in Paris, which they restored in an overtly Gothic style. Yet although his renovations reproduced past ideas, they were blended with his unique Gothic sensibilities, which took them beyond restoration into the realm of invention. Nonetheless, in his *Analytical Dictionary of French Architecture from the XIth to the XVIth Century* (1854–68) and his *Discourses on Architecture* (1863–72), Viollet-le-Duc dominated 19th-century theories of architectural restoration, and would exert a powerful influence on modern design.



Château de Pierrefonds, c.1400, restored by Viollet-le-Duc 1857–85